

Words That Refuse to Repeat

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Abstract

Take any long text and start looking for repeated chunks sitting right next to each other: *murmur* has one, *couscous* has one, and if you type randomly for long enough you will eventually type the same letter three times running, or the same pair of letters twice in a row. This is not really a fact about language; it is a fact about finiteness. If you only have a handful of symbols to work with, repetition is very hard to avoid for long. The question this talk is built around is: how hard, exactly? And is it possible to avoid entirely, forever, if you choose your infinite sequence carefully enough?